

THE RETURN OF THE ARK!

TEXT: 2 Samuel 6:12-23 *“And it was told king David, saying, The LORD hath blessed the house of Obed-edom, and all that pertaineth unto him, because of the ark of God. So David went and brought up the ark of God from the house of Obed-edom into the city of David with gladness. 13. and it was so, that when they that bare the ark of the LORD had gone six paces, he sacrificed oxen and fatlings. 14. And David danced before the LORD with all his might; and David was girded with a linen ephod. 15. So David and all the house of Israel brought up the ark of the LORD with shouting, and with the sound of the trumpet. 16. And as the ark of the LORD came into the city of David, Michal Saul's daughter looked through a window, and saw king David leaping and dancing before the LORD; and she despised him in her heart. 17. and they brought in the ark of the LORD, and set it in his place, in the midst of the tabernacle that David had pitched for it: and David offered burnt offerings and peace offerings before the LORD. 18. and as soon as David had made an end of offering burnt offerings and peace offerings, he blessed the people in the name of the LORD of hosts. 19. And he dealt among all the people, even among the whole multitude of Israel, as well to the women as men, to every one a cake of bread, and a good piece of flesh, and a flagon of wine. So all the people departed every one to his house. 20. Then David returned to bless his household. And Michal the daughter of Saul came out to meet David, and said, How glorious was the*

king of Israel to day, who uncovered himself to day in the eyes of the handmaids of his servants, as one of the vain fellows shamelessly uncovereth himself!
21. And David said unto Michal, It was before the LORD, which chose me before thy father, and before all his house, to appoint me ruler over the people of the LORD, over Israel: therefore will I play before the LORD. 22. And I will yet be more vile than thus, and will be base in mine own sight: and of the maidservants which thou hast spoken of, of them shall I be had in honour. 23. Therefore Michal the daughter of Saul had no child unto the day of her death."

INTRO: In the storied history of Israel nothing is more significant than the Ark of the Covenant. The Ark of the Covenant contained the presence of Jehovah. This piece of furniture was the dwelling place of Jehovah among the Children of Israel. Today we want to look at the significance of the absence of the Ark from Israel, its return, and the varied responses to its homecoming.

I want to preface my remarks today by saying, it's a sad day in a person's life, home, or church when the presence of the Lord is not given the priority place to occupy, that it rightly deserves! I also want to say that it's a glad day when the presence of the Lord is returned to its rightful position.

The Ark of the Covenant was a container of omnipotence:

- The blueprint was divinely furnished...

- The plans were carefully and meticulously followed by Moses, the Law-Giver...
- The materials for this precious piece of furniture were unequalled...

The reason the Ark occupied such a place of veneration was because it was the place where Jehovah dwelt among Israel. It was first in the order of tabernacle furniture and as such it was a constant reminder of God's presence.

I. THE ABSENCE OF THE ARK...

In the early days of Israel, the Ark occupied a very prominent place of importance. During the time of the wilderness wandering there were times when Israel would be commanded to pick up their tents and move from place to place and when this group of nomads continued their pilgrimage, the Ark was the piece of furniture which led the way. During this time, tremendous, miraculous victories were wrought by the hand of those who followed the Ark! Nothing has changed; great victories await those who choose to follow the Ark!

The Ark was a means of preservation. Joshua 4:7 (KJV) ***"Then ye shall answer them, That the waters of Jordan were cut off before the ark of the covenant of the LORD; when it passed over Jordan, the waters of Jordan were cut off: and these stones shall be for a memorial unto the children of Israel for ever."***

During the days of Eli, the Ark was captured by the Philistines. 1 Samuel 7:1-2 (KJV) ***"And the men of***

Kirjath-earim came, and fetched up the ark of the LORD, and brought it into the house of Abinadab in the hill, and sanctified Eleazar his son to keep the ark of the LORD. 2. And it came to pass, while the ark abode in Kirjath-jearim, that the time was long; for it was twenty years: and all the house of Israel lamented after the LORD.”

Much to the dismay and destruction of Israel, the Ark was taken from its rightful position and relegated to an inferior spiritual climate. For more than twenty years the Ark was:

- Dislocated...
- Misplaced...
- Neglected...
- Abused...
- Misused...

I want us to look at what happens when the Ark is absent from its rightful position. For more than twenty years the Israelites were oppressed by the Philistines! There will always be bondage when the Ark is misplaced.

Sin became so rampant that it influenced the entire household of the High Priest! (Eli and his sons)

When the Ark is not given a prominent place of reverence, sin will be allowed to go un-confessed and unchecked, thus bringing God’s people under enslavement to sin. Placing such a Holy piece of furniture under the control of Eli’s evil sons; spelled defeat for Israel. The results of such sinful people

handling and controlling the presence of God are as follows:

- Thirty thousand people are slain...
- The Ark is captured by the Philistines...
- Hophni and Phinehas are slain...
- Upon receiving word of the capture of the Ark and the death of his sons, Eli has a tragic accident, falling off of his stool he breaks his neck and dies... Eli's daughter-in-law gives birth to a child and names him Ichabod... The meaning of the name Ichabod is the Glory of the Lord has departed from Israel."

How sad! All because the Ark has been misplaced! 1 Samuel 6:19-20 (KJV) ***"And he smote the men of Bethshemesh, because they had looked into the ark of the LORD, even he smote of the people fifty thousand and threescore and ten men: and the people lamented, because the LORD had smitten many of the people with a great slaughter. 20. And the men of Bethshemesh said, Who is able to stand before this holy LORD God? and to whom shall he go up from us?"*** 50,070 men of Bethshemesh were killed by the hand of God for looking into the Ark. Remember this, if we are to properly handle the presence of the Lord we must be striving for holiness. Attempting to hold to God with one hand and to the world with the other hand is one of the most dangerous things a person can do.

II. THE RETURN OF THE ARK...

There is a tremendous need in the modern church for the return of the presence of the Lord. While we

desperately need His presence among us we would do well to remember, there can be no shortcuts in returning the Ark to its proper place!

After becoming King, David attempts to return the Ark from Kirjath-jearim to Zion. In doing so, David permits those who have the responsibility of transportation to use a new cart. The church of the twenty first century has built new carts to transport an anemic substitute for the presence of God:

- Discover the champion in you... There is nothing wrong with discovering the champion in you, if you have walked away from an ungodly lifestyle and made Jesus Lord, but this **MUST** be about more than creating a better self image.
- The best hour of your week... There is nothing wrong with having a wonderful hour of worship and fellowship with other believers but what if God is not finished within sixty minutes? Are we to assume that once we have spent sixty minutes in His presence and the presence of other believers, we have got it over with for the week? What ever happened to tarrying before the Lord; intercessory prayer; and walking with God twenty-four-seven?
- Seeker friendly churches... I do not want to attempt to build a seeker hostile church but when the wishes of the multitude rather than the direction of the Holy Spirit becomes the order of the day something needs to be flip-flopped!

We do not need more new carts, what we need is the return of the Ark!

I believe that David's intentions were good and his motives were pure, however he makes a grave mistake by overlooking the fact that according to the Law of Moses, the Priests were supposed to carry the Ark! Notice what happens here. I Chronicles 13:9-10 (KJV) ***"And when they came unto the threshing floor of Chidon, Uzza put forth his hand to hold the ark; for the oxen stumbled. 10. And the anger of the LORD was kindled against Uzza, and he smote him, because he put his hand to the ark: and there he died before God."*** One thing the modern church world would do well to understand is that God will never approve any man made alternatives for His presence. Uzza became a casualty of attempting to carry the Ark on a new cart. Many casualties are being created in churches that never take people into the presence of the Lord. The people are living under the assumption that everything is alright when sin has not been dealt with in their life. The leaders of such churches will stand before God with the blood of their ignorant parishioners dripping from their finger-tips! Trust me, every shepherd will stand accountable to God for how they led the people!

When engaging Goliath, David almost made the fatal mistake of wearing Saul's armor. If he had faced Goliath with Saul's armor, he would not have been successful. Rather than making such a lethal error he said ***"I have not proven these"*** and he faced the giant with a slingshot, five rocks, and a shepherd's staff. The most important part of his plan of attack against such a formidable foe is found in the fact that he said

to Goliath, ***"You come to me with a sword and a spear, but I come to you in the name of the Lord of Hosts, the God of the armies of Israel."***

The question remains, once the Ark is lost, how do you properly return it? First Samuel chapter seven gives us three conditions for returning the Ark:

- Return to God with all our heart... (Make His presence a priority)
- Put away all strange gods... (What could be more important than to have His presence among us?)
- The Priests (Leadership) are to carry the Ark... (A church will never rise above its leadership. Rather than electing people who are successful or popular we should be electing people who make God a priority)

Are we prepared for the return of the Ark? Obviously, not everyone in Israel was prepared for the presence of God to return! As much as King David wanted the Ark returned to Zion, he obviously was ill-prepared, according to second Samuel chapter six. It seems David put the Ark on a new cart, knowing full well that it was to be carried by the Priests. This mistake cost Uzza his life. As a result of this disastrous turn of events, David parks the Ark in the house of Obed-edom. The Ark had been in the house of Obed-edom for three months. The Ark proved to be a blessing to the house of Obed-edom. I think it would be safe to say, that when the Ark entered his house:

- His crutches were no longer needed...
- He could discard his hearing aid...

- His wife's arthritis was healed...
- His children became more obedient and started making better grades in school...
- His cows produced more milk...
- His crops were much more profitable...
- His fruit trees yielded more fruit...

I'm not 100% sure that Obed-edom was ready to give up the Ark for the overall good of Israel. What are we willing to give up so that the Ark can return to the church? When the Ark begins to move, of necessity there will be a lot of things that will begin to change. Do you think we are ready for change which paves the way for God to come back to church?

III. RESPONSES TO THE HOMECOMING OF THE ARK...

After three months King David returns to the house of Obed-edom, to retrieve the Ark. After three months David did not just wake up one morning, yawn, stretch, touch the ends of his toes twice and the back of his head once and say, ***"I think we'll go get the Ark today!"*** No! The entire three months had been used preparing for the return of the Ark. David no doubt read the Law of Moses concerning the handling of the Ark to insure its safe return. As a result, he used the proper priests, who had been consecrated to carry it!

Notice with me what changed in this effort of returning the Ark:

- The proper people carried it... (The Priests – The leadership **MUST** be in the forefront!
Many attempts of God to send His presence into

the church have been stopped by leadership which is indifferent!) (My experience in Malvern)

- The proper sacrificing took place... 2 Samuel 6:13 (KJV) ***“And it was so, that when they that bare the Ark of the LORD had gone six paces, he sacrificed oxen and fatlings.”*** The number of oxen and fatlings he offered is not stated here. However, 1 Chronicles 15:26 states that ***“Seven bullocks and seven ram’s”*** were used. If the proper meat offerings and drink offerings were made with each sacrifice, as commanded in Numbers fifteen, the total estimated cost according to today’s prices would be as follows:

1. 7 Bullocks @ \$325 ea.....\$2,275.00
2. 7 Rams @ \$20 ea.....\$140.00
3. 35 quarts of oil @ \$1.40 ea.....\$49.00
4. 35 quarts of wine @ \$1.60 ea.....\$56.00
5. 17 ½ gallons of flour @ \$.80 ea.....\$14.00
6. **Total Estimated Cost.....\$2,534.00**

Think of this: Every eighteen feet they prayed, worshiped, and sacrificed! This was repeated every six steps! (Demonstrate this)

There was a whole lot of praying, worshipping and sacrificing going on. This went far beyond discovering the champion within; the best hour of your week; and finding out what the audience wanted; this was done to return the presence of the Lord to its proper place of prominence among Israel. Let me assure you we must pray worship and sacrifice to see His Glory among us as well.

Notice the varied responses to the homecoming of the Ark:

- David... 2 Samuel 6:14-15 (KJV) “***And David danced before the LORD with all his might; and David was girded with a linen ephod. 15. So David and all the house of Israel brought up the ark of the LORD with shouting, and with the sound of the trumpet.***” When the Glory of God has been lost, there is a reason to celebrate when it returns! The return of the Ark spelled revival. There are those who want revival; there are those who tolerate revival; there are fire hunters who want to warm by a fire which has already been prayed down; there are fire builders; to some revival is a delight; to others it is drudgery. David was given to emotion, he was sitting on ready, it didn’t take much to detonate his powder. When the Ark finally was returned in the proper manner; this sweet singer of Israel; this psalm-writer; this happy king could no longer contain his exuberance. His excitement was placed on exhibition for all of Israel to see. The joy David experienced in bringing back the Ark expressed itself in a holy dance. This may be the reason David could say, “***Thou has turned for me my mourning into dancing; Thou hast put off my sackcloth and girded me with gladness.***”
- Michal... 2 Samuel 6:16 (KJV) “***And as the ark of the LORD came into the city of David, Michal Saul's daughter looked through a window, and saw king David leaping and***

dancing before the LORD; and she despised him in her heart. 20. Then David returned to bless his household. And Michal the daughter of Saul came out to meet David, and said, How glorious was the king of Israel to day, who uncovered himself to day in the eyes of the handmaids of his servants, as one of the vain fellows shamelessly F36 uncovereth himself!"

Michal, like Miriam of old, should have been leading the women in the dance of victory.

Exodus 15:20 (KJV) *"And Miriam the prophetess, the sister of Aaron, took a timbrel in her hand; and all the women went out after her with timbrels and with dances."* Someone said, *"In David, Michal loved the brave hero and exalted king, not the servant of God."* She had more of Saul's daughter in her than David's wife. Does that sound like anybody you know?

Notice the result of the decision of each of these people, in response to the homecoming of the Ark:

- David... When David heard his wife's strong rebuff and criticism, he said, *"I will be more vile than this. I will be base in mine own sight."* Someone paraphrased this passage as follows: *"Woman, you ain't seen nothing yet! Just wait until the night service and I will run through a troop and leap over a wall."* I am not sure what David was singing as he worshipped at the return of the Ark but it may have been Psalm 24. He may have sung the first part which goes – *"Lift up ye gates and be lifted up, ye everlasting bars and the king of glory shall*

come in.” The choir responded – “*Who is this king of glory?*” David answers – “*The Lord of hosts, he is the king of glory.*” The returning of the Ark triggered a flood of gratitude in the hearts of the people. David became known as a man after God’s own heart!

- Michal... Poor Michal; poor unhappy Michal; she criticized her husband; she cared nothing for the glory of God; she was like Esau, a profane person. She contributed nothing to the fanfare surrounding the return of the Ark; in fact, she steadfastly resisted such a thing. As a result, she was barren from the day of her criticism.

How many people do you think are in the same condition spiritually because of their response to the Ark? After Michal’s criticism of spiritual matters she became barren. She could never hope to be the mother of a future king, nor could she hope to be counted in the genealogy of Christ.

Let me ask you, where will you be when the Ark returns? Will you be a supporter of the return of His presence or will you be standing in the path, not intending to go in yourself and being critical of those who do?

SONG: “I HAVE DECIDED TO FOLLOW JESUS.”

Places preached:

1st A/G Malvern, AR 3/5/95 AM & PM

1st A/G Fouke, AR 5/28/95 AM & PM

New Bethel A/G Ft. Smith, AR 10/9/95 Sectional
Council
Christian Temple, Houston, TX 11/25/07 AM & PM